

Saturday, January 1, 2000

There's no one quite like Attla



Kurt Sairikko photo

ON THE ROAD—North Pole musher George Attla drives his team down the snow-covered street during the Nenana Sprint Races during the late 1970s.

'Huslia Hustler' heads list of all-time mushers

By CHRIS TALBOTT
Staff Writer

Champion dog mushers usually come and go, their fortunes tied to one or two lead dogs that peak gloriously then flame out with age.

For nearly 40 years, North Pole sprint musher George Attla managed to stay on top of the sport for a very simple reason.

"That's leaders," Attla said. "That's the whole answer."

Attla had a string of amazing lead dogs before his retirement last year at the age of 65. Even more amazing was the fact that almost all of them came from his own dog yard, allowing him to become the century's most distinguished mushing champion.

Only three dogs from other

kennels—Johnny and Blue from the yards of Larry Westlake and Georgie Frank, respectively, and Trot, bred by his brother Alfred—ever led one of his championship teams.

Dogs like Lingo and Freckles, Moses and Keys led him to eight Open North American Championships, 10 Fur Rendezvous titles and 10 Tok Race of Champions wins in his career. No one knows for sure, but Attla figures he won more than 100 races in his four decades, from the villages of Alaska to the villages of New England and everywhere in between.

That success has made Attla the world's most recognizable dog musher. He is known in all cold-weather corners of the globe.

He had a movie made about him ("Spirit of the Wind"), was the subject of countless books and authored "Everything I Know About Training and Racing Sled Dogs," long the bible of the sport.

That recognition was earned through hard work, sacrifice and winning, always winning. He was the target of several different generations of young mushers, the exemplar of the sport.

Charlie Champaine still fondly remembers what it was like the first time he was able to beat Attla.

"George Attla was the stellar person in the sport," Champaine said. "He has racing records ... that will probably never be broken. It would be like beating

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Muhammed Ali as a young up-and-coming racer. It was a great accomplishment to beat him and a learning experience. He taught me some stuff by the school of hard knocks."

As any musher will tell you, finding lead dogs is a chore that can drive a racer insane. Championship-quality leaders are special dogs with the ability to run at more than 20 mph for at least 20 miles, withstand the pressure of 20 dogs barreling down from behind and the sight of thousands of loud spectators in front of them.

Attla was born with a feel for identifying dogs that could meet those rigorous criteria.

"It was a gift, just a feeling," Attla said. "It's not something you really see (in the dogs' physical build). I really don't know what it is to be honest with you. Even with the pups, I could tell. It's something you couldn't teach."

That gift was probably part genetic, part environmental. Attla was born in Huslia, the son of a long line of dog men. He was surrounded by huskies from birth and still remembers his first pups, Buster and Jimbo, as if they were championship leaders. Attla believes those dogs helped him get over the debilitating effects of polio, which left him with a pronounced limp.

"They were trap-line dogs," Attla said. "When I started having problems with my legs my father gave me the pups. Buster was the leader and Jimbo would follow him. They were good dogs."

Over the years, Attla returned to Huslia and the nearby village of Hughes again and again for dogs of the highest caliber. But they became harder and harder to find as the snowmachine began to dominate. Now Attla wonders if there ever will be another Native child born with the ability to see into a dog's heart like the men he remembers growing up.

"The dog men in those days were better dog people than today just because it was a simpler lifestyle," Attla said. "They all lived off the country. They had to hunt and trap to survive. We had to understand all the animals. It was easy to understand dogs. It was hard to understand the animals you were trying to catch."

Other mushers among the century's best in alphabetical order are:

■ **Charlie Boulding, Manley:** The musher with the hippy grandfather look is one of only two racers to win the Yukon Quest twice and has lately become a top 10 Iditarod fixture. He is one of only two mushers to finish both the Yukon Quest and the Iditarod in the same year.

■ **Susan Butcher, Fairbanks:** A four-time winner of the Iditarod, Butcher is credited with bringing the Iditarod to international attention and fame. Although she didn't reach her

goal of becoming the first woman to win the race, she was certainly the most prominent champion until her recent retirement.

■ **Charlie Champaine, Salcha:** Champaine picked up his first Fur Rendezvous victory in 1984, but it wasn't until the latter part of the decade that he and wife Roxy Wright Champaine began to dominate the sport. Alternating who would drive the team from year to year, the duo won the Ronny from 1988-93 without losing a single heat (18 straight). Champaine is retired now but runs a successful dog feed business and is still an innovator. He changed distance racing recently with his freeze-dried food.

■ **Roxy Wright Champaine, Salcha:** The Salcha resident is the first lady of the sport—the first to win the Fur Rendezvous, the first to win the Open North American, and so on. She's an eight-time winner of the Women's Fur Ronny and has run both the Iditarod and the Alpirod. Daughter of Gareth, wife of Charlie Champaine and mother of Yukon Quest champion Ramy Brooks, she is the centerpiece of the state's most successful mushing family.

■ **Kathy Frost, Fairbanks:** With her husband, Lloyd Lowry, Frost is perhaps the most successful modern, small-kennel musher. An eight-time winner of the Women's Rendezvous, she is tied with Roxy Wright Champaine for most victories and will go for her ninth this February. She also has victories in many eight-dog and open-class races around the state. Either she or Lowry has been president or a member of the ADMA board since 1982, helping to shape the club's races into the world's premier schedule.

■ **Carl Huntington, Galena:** The musher is the only man to win the Open North American (1977), the Fur Rendezvous (1973 and 1977) and the Iditarod (1974), an amazing feat. Attla calls him the best dog trainer he ever met.

■ **Jeff King, Denali Park:** The California-born King has won just about every long- or mid-distance race that exists and some that don't anymore. He is one of three mushers to win both the Yukon Quest and the Iditarod and has three Iditarod victories, third on the career list.

■ **The Kokrines:** For three generations, the Kokrine family of Tanana and later Fairbanks was a fixture in the Interior racing circuit. The winning ways started with Bergman Kokrine, who won the 165-mile precursor to the Open North American in 1940. His brother Andy won the ONAC two years in a row in 1946-47. The tradition continued into modern times when Bergman's grandson, Marvin, won the 1988 ONAC.

■ **Steve and Rosie Lasosky, Fairbanks:** The husband and wife team didn't win a lot of races, but they raised a line of dogs considered the best for a decade in the 1940s and '50s. Even today, sprint mushers proudly point out the Lasosky strain in their bloodlines.

■ **Linda Leonard and Harvey Drake, Salcha:** Leonard was dominant on the limited sprint mushing scene until her retirement last year. She won a record 13 Limited North American eight-dog titles from 1977 to 1998, 12 10- and six-dog Gold Run titles and holds just about every speed record there is. With Drake at her side, their kennel has been consistently at the top of the standings since the early '70s. Drake won the 1976 and '80 Open North Americans, beating his opponents with smaller teams and an innovative mind that brought many changes to the sport.

■ **Sonny Lindner, Delta Junction:** Winner of the first Yukon Quest, Lindner was an Iditarod force early in his career with four top 10 finishes, including second in 1981. In



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MUSH ON—George Attla drives his team along the trail during the 1987 Open North American Sled Dog Championships in 1987. Attla has won more Open North American titles, eight, and more Fur Rendezvous World Championship crowns, 10, than any other musher.

1992, he became one of only two mushers to finish both the Quest (No. 2) and the Iditarod (No. 22) in the same year.

■ **The Mackeys:** Father Dick won the closest Iditarod with a one-second victory in 1978. Son Rick won in 1983 to make them the only father-son duo to win the Iditarod. Rick became only the third racer in history to win both the Iditarod and the Yukon Quest in 1997.

■ **Jerry Riley, Nenana:** The 1976 Iditarod champion and Yukon Quest runner-up will be running the 1,000-mile race for the first time since the '80s this year. A fixture in Western Alaska, Riley has won countless mid-distance races and holds a blistering record of a little more than 68 hours in the Kobuk 440.

■ **Joe Runyan, Nenana:** With an incredible focus, Runyan won the Iditarod, the Yukon Quest and the Alpirod in his career, which lasted only about a decade. He is the only musher to accomplish that trifecta and one of only three to win both major distance races.

■ **John Schandeleier, Paxson:** The trapper/commercial fisherman is one of only two racers to win the Yukon Quest twice. More importantly to Schandeleier, though, are his two awards from veterinarians for his dog care.

■ **LeRoy Shank, Fairbanks:** Shank finished the Iditarod twice and the Yukon Quest once, but is better known for an idea. Shank and Roger Williams came up with the concept for the Yukon Quest as an alternative to

the Iditarod. The Quest has become one of the top two or three winter events in Fairbanks and draws many of the sport's top names annually.

■ **Horace Smoke, Stevens Village:** He became the first racer to win three straight Open North Americans, taking the race from 1951-53. His sprint-racing feats earned him the nickname "Holy Smoke."

■ **Jeff Studdert, Fairbanks:** Many of those who remember him credit Studdert with making sprint mushing in Fairbanks what it is today. He was a charter member of the Alaska Dog Musher's Association along with founders Mike Agbaba and Jack Mansfield and his fund-raising efforts helped establish the club's series of races. He helped procure the 40 acres needed for the racegrounds, which carry his name.

■ **Rick Swenson, Two Rivers:** He is the king of the Iditarod with a record five victories and a career history that dwarfs any other. Until 1998, Swenson had never finished out of the top 10. Like Attla his career has spanned more than 30 years with victories in three different decades. After last year's fourth-place finish he predicted victory in 2000.

■ **Gareth Wright, Fairbanks:** The patriarch of the Wright dynasty, he won the Open North American in both 1950 and 1983. Wright is perhaps best known as the creator of the aurora husky line, a cunning cross of traditional sled dogs and hounds than now pervades the sport, especially in Europe.